SOCIOCULTURAL FALSE BELIEF #11 · COMMUNITY AND NEIGHBORHOOD

“What other people think of me is what matters most.”

✦ ✦ ✦

Where it often comes from

In close communities, reputation can feel like survival. Gossip, church talk, and neighborhood watchfulness teach us to monitor how we look to others. Social media has widened that audience. We learn to adjust ourselves to be accepted and fear being talked about.

What Scripture teaches

Paul asks, “Am I now seeking the approval of men, or of God?” Proverbs says, “The fear of man is a snare, but whoever trusts in the LORD is set securely on high.” God told Samuel, “Man sees the outward appearance, but the LORD sees the heart.” Jesus warned about doing good “to be seen by men.” Proverbs adds that “a good name is more desirable than great riches,” which means character matters, but it is built by integrity, not by managing impressions. The final opinion that matters is God’s.

> *“The fear of man is a snare, but whoever trusts in the LORD is set securely on high”* (Proverbs 29:25).

Also see

> “Am I now seeking the approval of men, or of God? Or am I striving to please men? If I were still trying to please men, I would not be a servant of Christ” (Galatians 1:10).

> “A good name is more desirable than great riches; favor is better than silver and gold” (Proverbs 22:1).

> “The LORD is on my side; I will not be afraid. What can man do to me?” (Psalm 118:6).

> “Conduct yourselves with such honor among the Gentiles that, though they slander you as evildoers, they may see your good deeds and glorify God on the day He visits us” (1 Peter 2:12).

Common self-statements

- If people think badly of me, I am ruined.
- I have to manage how I come across.
- Their opinion decides my worth.
- I cannot stand being talked about.
- I must keep up appearances.
- I have to please everyone.

Common logical errors

- Mind reading: Assuming I know what others think.
- Spotlight effect: Believing everyone is watching and judging me.
- Should statements: Insisting that I must always be approved.
- Emotional reasoning: Feeling exposed and concluding that I am judged.

Challenging questions

- Whose opinion do I fear most, and why?
- What have I done to win approval that did not feel like me?

- What does a good name actually rest on?
- What does Scripture say about the fear of man?
- What would change if I cared most about God's view?
- What is one place I can be more honest?

Truth summary

> A good name is built by integrity, not by managing impressions. The fear of man is a snare, and God's view of me is what matters most. I can live honestly and let my character speak.

Related Pearls topics

Click a topic to open it in the Pearls Scripture Search:

- Pride
- Fear
- Self-Esteem, Low
- Humility
- Trust

Godly Counsel Lessons:

From the book *Godly Counsel* by Dr. Brian Campbell. Click a lesson to open it. You can read it on screen or print it.

- Pride
- Self-Esteem, Low

Listen: Overcoming Anxiety

> Overcoming Anxiety · Dr. Brian Campbell · about 18 minutes

Songs that speak truth to this belief

Voice of Truth — Casting Crowns
Test accusing or frightening messages against God's truth.

You Say — Lauren Daigle
God's loving assessment challenges identity based only on weakness or feelings.

Who Am I — Casting Crowns
Being known and cared for by God rests on His love rather than personal importance.

Blessed Assurance — Larry Ford and Lillie Knauls with Gaither
This classic hymn celebrates belonging to Christ and resting in His salvation.

Each morning ask: "If I truly believed God's truth instead of this lie, how would I think, speak, and act today?"

HOMEWORK · REPLACE AND REHEARSE

My Plan for Replacing "What other people think of me is what matters most"

✦ ✦ ✦

Read through each section and check the one that fits you best. If none of them fit, write your own. One choice per section is enough. A truth you choose for yourself will stick better than one handed to you.

Name: _____ Date started: _____

1 How strongly do I believe the lie?

Rate it now so you can see your progress later.

"What other people think of me is what matters most." I believe this _____ % (0 = not at all, 100 = completely)

2 My best question

The one question I will ask myself every time the lie shows up.

- ☐ Whose opinion do I fear?
- ☐ What do I do to win approval?
- ☐ What does a good name rest on?
- ☐ What does God think?
- ☐ Where can I be honest?
- ☐ What will I do differently?

My own question: _____

3 My replacement truth

The statement I will say to myself instead of the lie.

- ☐ The fear of man is a snare.
- ☐ God sees the heart.
- ☐ A good name comes from integrity.
- ☐ I seek God's approval first.
- ☐ I do not have to please everyone.
- ☐ The Lord is on my side.

In my own words: _____

4 My Scripture

The verse that speaks most directly to me. This is the one I will memorize.

- ☐ **Proverbs 29:25**
  "The fear of man is a snare, but whoever trusts in the LORD is set securely on high."
- ☐ **Galatians 1:10**
  "Am I now seeking the approval of men, or of God? Or am I striving to please men? If I were still trying to please men, I would not be a servant of Christ."
- ☐ **Proverbs 22:1**
  "A good name is more desirable than great riches; favor is better than silver and gold."

A verse I found myself: _____

Practicing the Truth

✦ ✦ ✦

5 My practice plan

Everyone does the first four. Then pick one or two extra tools.

EVERYONE DOES THESE

- [ ] Make my Truth Card (below). Carry it and read it at least three times a day.
- [ ] Memorize my Scripture from Step 4.
- [ ] Listen to one song each day from "Songs that speak truth to this belief" on my card, and fill in my song journal (below).
- [ ] Set reminders to silently repeat my truth. Check one or more:
  - ☐ A buzz: my watch or phone vibrates every _____ minutes
  - ☐ An everyday event: every time I _____
  - ☐ A visual reminder: something I will see often, such as a sticky note on my mirror, my truth as the background picture on my phone, or a note on my car dashboard.

PICK ONE OR TWO THAT FIT ME

- [ ] Honest, not impressive: Each week, note one time you chose honesty over impression.
- [ ] My name in Scripture: Write a personal reminder based on my verse and read it aloud. Keep this application separate from the Bible quotation.

  For example, Proverbs 29:25 becomes: "Sarah can write: "I trust the Lord, so I am set securely on high.""
- [ ] Gratitude journal: Each night, write three things I thank God for.
- [ ] Truth recording: Record my own voice reading my Truth Card and verse, and listen in the car or on a walk.
- [ ] Reading: The "Fear" topic in Pearls.
- [ ] Listening: The Overcoming Anxiety audio by Dr. Brian Campbell. Tap to play.

6 My action step this week

Do one thing that tests the lie in real life.

Choose steps you can do safely. If there is violence, coercion, or fear of retaliation, seek private professional support before trying anything with the other person. In an emergency call 911.

- [ ] Name the audience. Write whose opinions you fear most.
- [ ] Test the fear. Note what people actually say or do.
- [ ] Choose integrity. Do one thing because it is right, not because it is seen.
- [ ] Pray Psalm 118:6. Say it before a hard moment.

What I will do: _____

When: _____

What the lie predicts will happen: _____

7 End-of-week check-in

Bring this page to your next session.

What actually happened: _____

_____

What I learned: _____

The lie "What other people think of me is what matters most": _____ % My truth: _____ %

Daily practice tracker

Day	Read my card	Said my verse	Used my reminder	Integrity chosen
Mon				
Tue				
Wed				
Thu				
Fri				
Sat				
Sun				

My song journal

After each day's song, write what it told you that challenges the lie.

Day	Song I listened to	What it told me that challenges the lie
Mon		
Tue		
Wed		
Thu		
Fri		
Sat		
Sun		

My Truth Card

THE LIE

~~What other people think of me is what matters most.~~

THE TRUTH

GOD'S WORD

Copy onto a 3×5 card, or cut along the dashed line and carry it with you.

Prayer

Lord, I have lived under the weight of others' opinions. Free me from the fear of man, and let me live honestly before You. Amen.

Scripture quotations are from the Berean Standard Bible (BSB), which is in the public domain.

SOCIOCULTURAL FALSE BELIEF #12 · COMMUNITY AND NEIGHBORHOOD

"I'll never escape where I grew up."

✦ ✦ ✦

Where it often comes from

Some neighborhoods carry poverty, crime, addiction, or limited opportunity, and people who grow up there may feel marked for life. Others live in small towns where everyone knows their family history. We may feel trapped by the environment, by relationships that pull us back, or by the belief that leaving is impossible.

What Scripture teaches

God said to Abram, "Leave your country, your kindred, and your father's household, and go to the land I will show you." The Lord promises, "I am about to do something new... I will make a way in the wilderness and streams in the desert." Paul writes, "If anyone is in Christ, he is a new creation." Escape is not always about moving. Some are called to leave, and others to stay and be a light. Either way, where you grew up does not have to define where you are going.

> *"Then the LORD said to Abram, 'Leave your country, your kindred, and your father's household, and go to the land I will show you.'"* (Genesis 12:1).

Also see

> "'Do not call to mind the former things; pay no attention to the things of old. Behold, I am about to do something new; even now it is coming. Do you not see it? Indeed, I will make a way in the wilderness and streams in the desert.'" (Isaiah 43:18–19).

> "Therefore if anyone is in Christ, he is a new creation. The old has passed away. Behold, the new has come!" (2 Corinthians 5:17).

> "Do not be conformed to this world, but be transformed by the renewing of your mind. Then you will be able to test and approve what is the good, pleasing, and perfect will of God" (Romans 12:2).

> "For I know the plans I have for you, declares the LORD, plans to prosper you and not to harm you, to give you a future and a hope" (Jeremiah 29:11).

Common self-statements

- I will always be trapped here.
- No one gets out.
- My past will follow me forever.
- I cannot become anything else.
- The pull of home is too strong.
- I do not know how to live differently.

Common logical errors

- Fortune telling: Predicting that I cannot change.
- Catastrophizing: Imagining that I am stuck permanently.
- All-or-nothing thinking: Believing I must either leave entirely or stay stuck.
- Emotional reasoning: Feeling stuck and concluding that I am.

Challenging questions

- What does “escape” mean to me, physically, emotionally, or both?
- Who has left or changed and how?
- What would a first realistic step look like?
- What parts of my background do I want to keep?
- Who can help me move forward?
- What does God say about new beginnings?

Truth summary

> Where I grew up shaped me, but it does not decide my future. God makes ways in the wilderness, and in Christ I am a new creation. With wise steps and support, I can build a new path.

Related Pearls topics

Click a topic to open it in the Pearls Scripture Search:

- Hopeless
- Will of God
- Guidance
- Hardship
- Trust

Godly Counsel Lessons:

From the book *Godly Counsel* by Dr. Brian Campbell. Click a lesson to open it. You can read it on screen or print it.

- Trouble/Hardship
- Thinking, Healthy

Listen: Overcoming Depression

> Overcoming Depression · Dr. Brian Campbell · about 20 minutes

Songs that speak truth to this belief

All Things New — Steven Curtis Chapman
God’s renewing work offers hope beyond failure, decay, and loss.

Chain Breaker — Zach Williams
Christ offers rescue and freedom to people who feel trapped by their past.

Amazing Grace My Chains Are Gone — Chris Tomlin
Salvation and freedom come through grace rather than earning acceptance.

Great Is Thy Faithfulness — CeCe Winans
This classic hymn recalls God’s steady mercy through changing circumstances.

Each morning ask: “If I truly believed God’s truth instead of this lie, how would I think, speak, and act today?”

HOMEWORK · REPLACE AND REHEARSE

My Plan for Replacing "I'll never escape where I grew up"

✦ ✦ ✦

Read through each section and check the one that fits you best. If none of them fit, write your own. One choice per section is enough. A truth you choose for yourself will stick better than one handed to you.

Name: _____ Date started: _____

1 How strongly do I believe the lie?

Rate it now so you can see your progress later.

"I'll never escape where I grew up." I believe this _____ % (0 = not at all, 100 = completely)

2 My best question

The one question I will ask myself every time the lie shows up.

- ☐ What does escape mean to me?
- ☐ Who has moved forward?
- ☐ What is my first step?
- ☐ What do I keep?
- ☐ Who can help?
- ☐ What does God say?

My own question: _____

3 My replacement truth

The statement I will say to myself instead of the lie.

- ☐ God can make a way in the wilderness.
- ☐ I am a new creation in Christ.
- ☐ My past does not decide my future.
- ☐ Change can be gradual.
- ☐ I can keep what is good.
- ☐ I am not alone on this road.

In my own words: _____

4 My Scripture

The verse that speaks most directly to me. This is the one I will memorize.

- ☐ **Genesis 12:1**
  "Then the LORD said to Abram, 'Leave your country, your kindred, and your father's household, and go to the land I will show you.'"
- ☐ **Isaiah 43:18–19**
  "'Do not call to mind the former things; pay no attention to the things of old. Behold, I am about to do something new; even now it is coming. Do you not see it? Indeed, I will make a way in the wilderness and streams in the desert.'"
- ☐ **2 Corinthians 5:17**
  "Therefore if anyone is in Christ, he is a new creation. The old has passed away. Behold, the new has come!"

A verse I found myself: _____

_____

Practicing the Truth

✦ ✦ ✦

5 My practice plan

Everyone does the first four. Then pick one or two extra tools.

EVERYONE DOES THESE

- [ ] Make my Truth Card (below). Carry it and read it at least three times a day.
- [ ] Memorize my Scripture from Step 4.
- [ ] Listen to one song each day from "Songs that speak truth to this belief" on my card, and fill in my song journal (below).
- [ ] Set reminders to silently repeat my truth. Check one or more:
  - ☐ A buzz: my watch or phone vibrates every _____ minutes
  - ☐ An everyday event: every time I _____
  - ☐ A visual reminder: something I will see often, such as a sticky note on my mirror, my truth as the background picture on my phone, or a note on my car dashboard.

PICK ONE OR TWO THAT FIT ME

- [ ] A step forward: Each week, record one step toward the life you want.
- [ ] My name in Scripture: Write a personal reminder based on my verse and read it aloud. Keep this application separate from the Bible quotation.

  For example, Isaiah 43:18–19 becomes: "Sarah can write: "God makes a way in the wilderness, and I am a new creation.""
- [ ] Gratitude journal: Each night, write three things I thank God for.
- [ ] Truth recording: Record my own voice reading my Truth Card and verse, and listen in the car or on a walk.
- [ ] Reading: The "Guidance" topic in Pearls.
- [ ] Listening: The Overcoming Depression audio by Dr. Brian Campbell. Tap to play.

6 My action step this week

Do one thing that tests the lie in real life.

Choose steps you can do safely. If there is violence, coercion, or fear of retaliation, seek private professional support before trying anything with the other person. In an emergency call 911.

- [ ] Define the goal. Write what "out" means for you.
- [ ] Find a guide. Ask someone who has moved forward for advice.
- [ ] Make a plan. Identify one skill, relationship, or resource to gain.
- [ ] Take a step. Do one thing this week toward it.

What I will do: _____

When: _____

What the lie predicts will happen: _____

7 End-of-week check-in

Bring this page to your next session.

What actually happened: _____

_____

What I learned: _____

The lie "I'll never escape where I grew up": _____ % My truth: _____ %

Daily practice tracker

Day	Read my card	Said my verse	Used my reminder	A step forward
Mon				
Tue				
Wed				
Thu				
Fri				
Sat				
Sun				

My song journal

After each day's song, write what it told you that challenges the lie.

Day	Song I listened to	What it told me that challenges the lie
Mon		
Tue		
Wed		
Thu		
Fri		
Sat		
Sun		

My Truth Card

THE LIE

~~I'll never escape where I grew up.~~

THE TRUTH

GOD'S WORD

Copy onto a 3×5 card, or cut along the dashed line and carry it with you.

Prayer

Lord, You lead people out and make a way where there is none. Show me my next step, give me wise people to walk with, and help me honor my past while moving on. Amen.

Scripture quotations are from the Berean Standard Bible (BSB), which is in the public domain.

SOCIOCULTURAL FALSE BELIEF #13 · COMMUNITY AND NEIGHBORHOOD

“I can't be trusted or respected because of my reputation.”

✦ ✦ ✦

Where it often comes from

A past mistake, a family name, rumors, or a label given in youth can follow us in a community. When people have decided who we are, it can seem pointless to try. We may live down to expectations or withdraw.

What Scripture teaches

Paul was feared by the church after persecuting believers, yet “Barnabas brought him to the apostles and described how Saul had seen the Lord,” and Saul became Paul. Proverbs says, “A good name is more desirable than great riches,” and a good name can be rebuilt through integrity: “He who walks in integrity walks securely.” Peter says, “Conduct yourselves with such honor among the Gentiles that, though they slander you as evildoers, they may see your good deeds and glorify God on the day He visits us.” Trust is rebuilt over time through changed behavior, and God’s view of us is not set by gossip.

> *“A good name is more desirable than great riches; favor is better than silver and gold”* (Proverbs 22:1).

Also see

> “When Saul arrived in Jerusalem, he tried to join the disciples, but they were all afraid of him, not believing that he was a disciple. Then Barnabas brought him to the apostles and described how Saul had seen the Lord, who spoke to him on the road to Damascus, and how Saul had spoken boldly in that city in the name of Jesus” (Acts 9:26–27).

> “He who walks in integrity walks securely, but he who perverts his ways will be found out” (Proverbs 10:9).

> “Conduct yourselves with such honor among the Gentiles that, though they slander you as evildoers, they may see your good deeds and glorify God on the day He visits us” (1 Peter 2:12).

> “Therefore if anyone is in Christ, he is a new creation. The old has passed away. Behold, the new has come!” (2 Corinthians 5:17).

Common self-statements

- Everyone already has their opinion of me.
- Nothing I do will change it.
- I will always be that person.
- They will never trust me.
- Why try to be better?
- My reputation is permanent.

Common logical errors

- Fortune telling: Predicting that no one will ever change their mind.
- Labeling: Accepting a label as my identity.
- All-or-nothing thinking: Believing reputation is either good or ruined.
- Emotional reasoning: Feeling ashamed and concluding that nothing can change.

Challenging questions

- What is my reputation, and what part is true, false, or outdated?
- Who has seen me change and treated me differently?
- What steps could rebuild trust over time?
- How did Barnabas help Paul, and who could be a Barnabas for me?
- What does God think of me now?
- What will I do consistently this month?

Truth summary

> A reputation can change over time through consistent integrity, and God knows me better than gossip does. I can own what is true, let go of what is not, and build trust one step at a time.

Related Pearls topics

Click a topic to open it in the Pearls Scripture Search:

- Guilt/Shame
- Forgiveness
- Repent
- Humility
- Witness

Godly Counsel Lessons:

From the book *Godly Counsel* by Dr. Brian Campbell. Click a lesson to open it. You can read it on screen or print it.

- Self-Esteem, Low
- Judgmental

Listen: Overcoming Depression

> Overcoming Depression · Dr. Brian Campbell · about 20 minutes

Songs that speak truth to this belief

Clean — Natalie Grant
God's cleansing grace challenges the belief that shame or sin makes a person beyond restoration.

Forgiveness — Matthew West
Ask God for help releasing resentment while working through real hurt.

All Things New — Steven Curtis Chapman
God's renewing work offers hope beyond failure, decay, and loss.

Amazing Grace — Reawaken Hymns
This classic hymn locates salvation and sustaining hope in grace rather than merit.

Each morning ask: "If I truly believed God's truth instead of this lie, how would I think, speak, and act today?"

HOMEWORK · REPLACE AND REHEARSE

My Plan for Replacing "I can't be trusted or respected because of my reputation"

✦ ✦ ✦

Read through each section and check the one that fits you best. If none of them fit, write your own. One choice per section is enough. A truth you choose for yourself will stick better than one handed to you.

Name: _____ Date started: _____

1 How strongly do I believe the lie?

Rate it now so you can see your progress later.

"I can't be trusted or respected because of my reputation." I believe this _____ % (0 = not at all, 100 = completely)

2 My best question

The one question I will ask myself every time the lie shows up.

- ☐ What is my reputation?
- ☐ What is true?
- ☐ Who has seen me change?
- ☐ What steps rebuild trust?
- ☐ Who could vouch for me?
- ☐ What will I do consistently?

My own question: _____

3 My replacement truth

The statement I will say to myself instead of the lie.

- ☐ A good name can be rebuilt.
- ☐ Integrity walks securely.
- ☐ God knows my heart.
- ☐ Barnabas-type friends exist.
- ☐ Trust grows with consistent behavior.
- ☐ I am a new creation.

In my own words: _____

4 My Scripture

The verse that speaks most directly to me. This is the one I will memorize.

- ☐ Proverbs 22:1
  "A good name is more desirable than great riches; favor is better than silver and gold."
- ☐ Acts 9:26–27
  "When Saul arrived in Jerusalem, he tried to join the disciples, but they were all afraid of him, not believing that he was a disciple. Then Barnabas brought him to the apostles and described how Saul had seen the Lord, who spoke to him on the road to Damascus, and how Saul had spoken boldly in that city in the name of Jesus."
- ☐ Proverbs 10:9
  "He who walks in integrity walks securely, but he who perverts his ways will be found out."

A verse I found myself: _____

HOMEWORK · REPLACE AND REHEARSE

Practicing the Truth

✦ ✦ ✦

5 My practice plan

Everyone does the first four. Then pick one or two extra tools.

EVERYONE DOES THESE

- [ ] Make my Truth Card (below). Carry it and read it at least three times a day.
- [ ] Memorize my Scripture from Step 4.
- [ ] Listen to one song each day from "Songs that speak truth to this belief" on my card, and fill in my song journal (below).
- [ ] Set reminders to silently repeat my truth. Check one or more:
  - ☐ A buzz: my watch or phone vibrates every _____ minutes
  - ☐ An everyday event: every time I _____
  - ☐ A visual reminder: something I will see often, such as a sticky note on my mirror, my truth as the background picture on my phone, or a note on my car dashboard.

PICK ONE OR TWO THAT FIT ME

- [ ] Trust rebuilt: Each week, note one act of consistent integrity.
- [ ] My name in Scripture: Write a personal reminder based on my verse and read it aloud. Keep this application separate from the Bible quotation.

  For example, Proverbs 10:9 becomes: "Sarah can write: "Walking in integrity, I can rebuild trust one step at a time.""
- [ ] Gratitude journal: Each night, write three things I thank God for.
- [ ] Truth recording: Record my own voice reading my Truth Card and verse, and listen in the car or on a walk.
- [ ] Reading: The "Repent" topic in Pearls.
- [ ] Listening: The Overcoming Depression audio by Dr. Brian Campbell. Tap to play.

6 My action step this week

Do one thing that tests the lie in real life.

Choose steps you can do safely. If there is violence, coercion, or fear of retaliation, seek private professional support before trying anything with the other person. In an emergency call 911.

- [ ] Sort the reputation. Write what is true, false, and outdated.
- [ ] Own and repair. Apologize or make amends where needed.
- [ ] Find a Barnabas. Ask a respected person to vouch or walk with you.
- [ ] Be consistent. Do small things reliably.

What I will do: _____

When: _____

What the lie predicts will happen: _____

7 End-of-week check-in

Bring this page to your next session.

What actually happened: _____

_____

What I learned: _____

The lie "I can't be trusted or respected because of my reputation": _____ % My truth: _____ %

Daily practice tracker

Day	Read my card	Said my verse	Used my reminder	Trust rebuilt
Mon				
Tue				
Wed				
Thu				
Fri				
Sat				
Sun				

My song journal

After each day's song, write what it told you that challenges the lie.

Day	Song I listened to	What it told me that challenges the lie
Mon		
Tue		
Wed		
Thu		
Fri		
Sat		
Sun		

My Truth Card

THE LIE

~~I can't be trusted or respected because of my reputation.~~

THE TRUTH

GOD'S WORD

Copy onto a 3×5 card, or cut along the dashed line and carry it with you.

Prayer

Lord, I carry a reputation that weighs on me. Help me own what is true, release what is not, and rebuild trust with integrity. Send me a Barnabas, and remind me You know my heart. Amen.

Scripture quotations are from the Berean Standard Bible (BSB), which is in the public domain.

SOCIOCULTURAL FALSE BELIEF #14 · COMMUNITY AND NEIGHBORHOOD

“If I don't fit in with my community, I'm worthless.”

✦ ✦ ✦

Where it often comes from

Tight-knit communities can offer deep belonging, and they can also demand conformity in politics, faith, lifestyle, or ambition. Those who differ may be quietly shunned. We may conclude that our worth depends on being accepted by them.

What Scripture teaches

Jesus did not fit in with the leaders of His community: “Only in his hometown, among his relatives, and in his own household is a prophet without honor.” Paul writes, “Do not be conformed to this world, but be transformed by the renewing of your mind.” Peter calls believers “foreigners and exiles.” Paul says, “our citizenship is in heaven,” and reminds us that we are “fellow citizens with the saints.” Not fitting a community is not the same as being worthless. Our value is set by the One who made us.

> *“Then Jesus said to them, ‘Only in his hometown, among his relatives, and in his own household is a prophet without honor.’”* (Mark 6:4).

Also see

> “Do not be conformed to this world, but be transformed by the renewing of your mind. Then you will be able to test and approve what is the good, pleasing, and perfect will of God” (Romans 12:2).

> “But our citizenship is in heaven, and we eagerly await a Savior from there, the Lord Jesus Christ” (Philippians 3:20).

> “Therefore you are no longer strangers and foreigners, but fellow citizens with the saints and members of God’s household” (Ephesians 2:19).

> “I praise You, for I am fearfully and wonderfully made. Marvelous are Your works, and I know this very well” (Psalm 139:14).

Common self-statements

- If they reject me, I am nothing.
- I have to conform to be worth anything.
- I do not measure up to what this community wants.
- Being different means being less.
- I have no value outside them.
- Without their approval I am nobody.

Common logical errors

- All-or-nothing thinking: Believing I am either accepted by my community or worthless.
- Emotional reasoning: Feeling rejected and concluding that I have no worth.
- Should statements: Insisting that I should fit in.
- Labeling: Calling myself worthless.

Challenging questions

- What does my community require for acceptance, and is it biblical?

- Which of my differences are sin, and which are simply differences?
- Who accepts me for who I am?
- What did Jesus experience with His own community?
- Where else might I find belonging?
- What does God say about my worth apart from any group?

Truth summary

> My worth does not depend on any community's approval. Jesus knew rejection from His own people. I am a citizen of God's kingdom and a member of His household, and I can seek communities that welcome me.

Related Pearls topics

Click a topic to open it in the Pearls Scripture Search:

- Self-Esteem, Low
- Worldly
- Loneliness
- Church
- Pride

Godly Counsel Lessons:

From the book *Godly Counsel* by Dr. Brian Campbell. Click a lesson to open it. You can read it on screen or print it.

- Self-Esteem, Low
- Love

Listen: Overcoming Depression

> Overcoming Depression · Dr. Brian Campbell · about 20 minutes

Songs that speak truth to this belief

Who Am I — Casting Crowns
Being known and cared for by God rests on His love rather than personal importance.

You Say — Lauren Daigle
God's loving assessment challenges identity based only on weakness or feelings.

If We Are the Body — Casting Crowns
The church is called to welcome and care for people rather than exclude or shame them.

Softly and Tenderly — Kristyn Getty with Vince Gill, Ellie Holcomb and Sierra Hull
This older hymn pictures Christ's gracious invitation to return rather than hide in shame.

Each morning ask: "If I truly believed God's truth instead of this lie, how would I think, speak, and act today?"

My Plan for Replacing "If I don't fit in with my community, I'm worthless"

✦ ✦ ✦

Read through each section and check the one that fits you best. If none of them fit, write your own. One choice per section is enough. A truth you choose for yourself will stick better than one handed to you.

Name: _____ Date started: _____

1 How strongly do I believe the lie?

Rate it now so you can see your progress later.

"If I don't fit in with my community, I'm worthless." I believe this _____ % (0 = not at all, 100 = completely)

2 My best question

The one question I will ask myself every time the lie shows up.

- ☐ What does my community require?
- ☐ Which are biblical?
- ☐ Who accepts me?
- ☐ What did Jesus experience?
- ☐ Where else can I belong?
- ☐ What does God say about my worth?

My own question: _____

3 My replacement truth

The statement I will say to myself instead of the lie.

- ☐ My worth is from God, not a group.
- ☐ Jesus experienced rejection too.
- ☐ I am a citizen of heaven.
- ☐ I am fearfully and wonderfully made.
- ☐ I can be different without being less.
- ☐ Other communities can welcome me.

In my own words: _____

4 My Scripture

The verse that speaks most directly to me. This is the one I will memorize.

- ☐ **Mark 6:4**
  "Then Jesus said to them, 'Only in his hometown, among his relatives, and in his own household is a prophet without honor.'"
- ☐ **Philippians 3:20**
  "But our citizenship is in heaven, and we eagerly await a Savior from there, the Lord Jesus Christ."
- ☐ **Ephesians 2:19**
  "Therefore you are no longer strangers and foreigners, but fellow citizens with the saints and members of God's household."

A verse I found myself: _____

_____

Practicing the Truth

✦ ✦ ✦

5 My practice plan

Everyone does the first four. Then pick one or two extra tools.

EVERYONE DOES THESE

- [ ] Make my Truth Card (below). Carry it and read it at least three times a day.
- [ ] Memorize my Scripture from Step 4.
- [ ] Listen to one song each day from "Songs that speak truth to this belief" on my card, and fill in my song journal (below).
- [ ] Set reminders to silently repeat my truth. Check one or more:
  - ☐ A buzz: my watch or phone vibrates every _____ minutes
  - ☐ An everyday event: every time I _____
  - ☐ A visual reminder: something I will see often, such as a sticky note on my mirror, my truth as the background picture on my phone, or a note on my car dashboard.

PICK ONE OR TWO THAT FIT ME

- [ ] Worth apart from approval: Each week, note one way you stayed true to yourself and one welcoming connection.
- [ ] My name in Scripture: Write a personal reminder based on my verse and read it aloud. Keep this application separate from the Bible quotation.

  For example, Ephesians 2:19 becomes: "Sarah can write: "I am a member of God's household, whatever a group thinks.""
- [ ] Gratitude journal: Each night, write three things I thank God for.
- [ ] Truth recording: Record my own voice reading my Truth Card and verse, and listen in the car or on a walk.
- [ ] Reading: The "Worldly" topic in Pearls.
- [ ] Listening: The Overcoming Depression audio by Dr. Brian Campbell. Tap to play.

6 My action step this week

Do one thing that tests the lie in real life.

Choose steps you can do safely. If there is violence, coercion, or fear of retaliation, seek private professional support before trying anything with the other person. In an emergency call 911.

- [ ] List the requirements. Write what the community expects.
- [ ] Sort them. Mark which are biblical and which are cultural.
- [ ] Seek other connections. Look for groups that welcome you.
- [ ] Read Ephesians 2:19. Remember where you belong.

What I will do: _____

When: _____

What the lie predicts will happen: _____

7 End-of-week check-in

Bring this page to your next session.

What actually happened: _____

_____

What I learned: _____

The lie "If I don't fit in with my community, I'm worthless": _____ % My truth: _____ %

Daily practice tracker

Day	Read my card	Said my verse	Used my reminder	Worth apart from approval
Mon				
Tue				
Wed				
Thu				
Fri				
Sat				
Sun				

My song journal

After each day's song, write what it told you that challenges the lie.

Day	Song I listened to	What it told me that challenges the lie
Mon		
Tue		
Wed		
Thu		
Fri		
Sat		
Sun		

My Truth Card

THE LIE

~~If I don't fit in with my community, I'm worthless.~~

THE TRUTH

GOD'S WORD

Copy onto a 3×5 card, or cut along the dashed line and carry it with you.

Prayer

Lord, You knew rejection. Remind me that my worth does not rest on any group's approval. Lead me to communities that welcome me, and keep me faithful to You. Amen.

Scripture quotations are from the Berean Standard Bible (BSB), which is in the public domain.

SOCIOCULTURAL FALSE BELIEF #15 · COMMUNITY AND NEIGHBORHOOD

“People in my town will always see me as I was.”

✦ ✦ ✦

Where it often comes from

In small towns and tight communities, people remember. A teenage mistake, a divorce, an addiction, or a family scandal may be recalled for decades. Even after real change, we may feel watched for relapse and seen through an old lens.

What Scripture teaches

Paul writes, “From now on we regard no one according to the flesh… Therefore if anyone is in Christ, he is a new creation. The old has passed away. Behold, the new has come!” The Lord says, “Do not call to mind the former things; pay no attention to the things of old. Behold, I am about to do something new.” After his conversion, Saul was feared by the church, but Barnabas stood with him. God is not limited by what people remember. While some will take time to see change, others will welcome it, and our task is to live faithfully and be patient.

> *“Therefore if anyone is in Christ, he is a new creation. The old has passed away. Behold, the new has come!”* (2 Corinthians 5:17).

Also see

> “‘Do not call to mind the former things; pay no attention to the things of old. Behold, I am about to do something new; even now it is coming. Do you not see it? Indeed, I will make a way in the wilderness and streams in the desert.’” (Isaiah 43:18–19).

> “When Saul arrived in Jerusalem, he tried to join the disciples, but they were all afraid of him, not believing that he was a disciple. Then Barnabas brought him to the apostles and described how Saul had seen the Lord, who spoke to him on the road to Damascus, and how Saul had spoken boldly in that city in the name of Jesus” (Acts 9:26–27).

> “He who walks in integrity walks securely, but he who perverts his ways will be found out” (Proverbs 10:9).

> “Do not be conformed to this world, but be transformed by the renewing of your mind. Then you will be able to test and approve what is the good, pleasing, and perfect will of God” (Romans 12:2).

Common self-statements

- They will never forget what I did.
- I will always be that person to them.
- No matter how I change, they will not see it.
- I cannot outlive my past here.
- Every look reminds me.
- People never change their minds about me.

Common logical errors

- Mind reading: Assuming I know what everyone remembers and thinks.
- Fortune telling: Predicting that no one will change their view.
- Overgeneralizing: Treating all townspeople as one mind.
- Labeling: Letting an old label stand for who I am now.

Challenging questions

- Who in my town has already responded to my change with kindness?
- What do I want to be known for in five years?
- What can I do consistently to show the change?
- Whose opinion do I weigh most, and why?
- What does God see when He looks at me now?
- Do I need a fresh start somewhere else, or can I stay with patience?

Truth summary

> God sees me as a new creation, and He is not limited by what others recall. Some people may take time to see my change. I can live faithfully, be patient, and look for those who welcome the new.

Related Pearls topics

Click a topic to open it in the Pearls Scripture Search:

- Born Again
- Forgiveness
- Guilt/Shame
- Humility
- Witness

Godly Counsel Lessons:

From the book *Godly Counsel* by Dr. Brian Campbell. Click a lesson to open it. You can read it on screen or print it.

- Self-Esteem, Low
- Thinking, Healthy

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Songs that speak truth to this belief

All Things New — Steven Curtis Chapman
God's renewing work offers hope beyond failure, decay, and loss.

Clean — Natalie Grant
God's cleansing grace challenges the belief that shame or sin makes a person beyond restoration.

Forgiveness — Matthew West
Ask God for help releasing resentment while working through real hurt.

Amazing Grace — Reawaken Hymns
This classic hymn locates salvation and sustaining hope in grace rather than merit.

Each morning ask: "If I truly believed God's truth instead of this lie, how would I think, speak, and act today?"

HOMEWORK · REPLACE AND REHEARSE

My Plan for Replacing "People in my town will always see me as I was"

✦ ✦ ✦

Read through each section and check the one that fits you best. If none of them fit, write your own. One choice per section is enough. A truth you choose for yourself will stick better than one handed to you.

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Rate it now so you can see your progress later.

"People in my town will always see me as I was." I believe this _____ % (0 = not at all, 100 = completely)

2 My best question

The one question I will ask myself every time the lie shows up.

- ☐ Who has responded kindly?
- ☐ What do I want to be known for?
- ☐ What can I do consistently?
- ☐ Whose opinion matters?
- ☐ What does God see?
- ☐ Do I need support?

My own question: _____

3 My replacement truth

The statement I will say to myself instead of the lie.

- ☐ I am a new creation.
- ☐ God does not call to mind the former things.
- ☐ Consistency builds a new story.
- ☐ Barnabas-type friends exist.
- ☐ Some will see the change in time.
- ☐ My identity is not their memory.

In my own words: _____

4 My Scripture

The verse that speaks most directly to me. This is the one I will memorize.

- ☐ 2 Corinthians 5:17
  "Therefore if anyone is in Christ, he is a new creation. The old has passed away. Behold, the new has come!"
- ☐ Isaiah 43:18–19
  "'Do not call to mind the former things; pay no attention to the things of old. Behold, I am about to do something new; even now it is coming. Do you not see it? Indeed, I will make a way in the wilderness and streams in the desert.'"
- ☐ Acts 9:26–27
  "When Saul arrived in Jerusalem, he tried to join the disciples, but they were all afraid of him, not believing that he was a disciple. Then Barnabas brought him to the apostles and described how Saul had seen the Lord, who spoke to him on the road to Damascus, and how Saul had spoken boldly in that city in the name of Jesus."

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PICK ONE OR TWO THAT FIT ME

- ☐ The new story: Each week, note one thing consistent with who you are now.
- ☐ My name in Scripture: Write a personal reminder based on my verse and read it aloud. Keep this application separate from the Bible quotation.
  For example, 2 Corinthians 5:17 becomes: "Sarah can write: "The old has passed away, and the new has come.""
- ☐ Gratitude journal: Each night, write three things I thank God for.
- ☐ Truth recording: Record my own voice reading my Truth Card and verse, and listen in the car or on a walk.
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Choose steps you can do safely. If there is violence, coercion, or fear of retaliation, seek private professional support before trying anything with the other person. In an emergency call 911.

- ☐ Tell the new story. Write who you are now in three sentences.
- ☐ Be consistent. Choose small, reliable actions.
- ☐ Find allies. Seek out those who encourage you.
- ☐ Release the old. Practice letting go of the need to be fully understood.

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When: _____

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THE LIE

~~People in my town will always see me as I was.~~

THE TRUTH

GOD'S WORD

Copy onto a 3×5 card, or cut along the dashed line and carry it with you.

Prayer

Father, You make all things new. Free me from living under others' memory, help me live faithfully, and give me patience while people see the change. Amen.

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